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The totalizing tournament

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In *The Highest Exam: How the Gaokao Shapes China*, authors Ruixue Jia, Hongbin Li, and Claire Cousineau deliver a definitive analysis of China's national college entrance examination. Li and Jia are two of the most well-known Chinese economists of their generation (now at Stanford and UC-San Diego, respectively); they are joined here by writer Claire Cousineau, formerly a researcher at Stanford. This collaboration results in what is arguably the most well-researched and data-backed treatment of this powerful social institution to date.

The book tackles China's national college entrance examination, the *gaokao*. For international observers unfamiliar with the phenomenon, the *gaokao* is far more than a standardized test like the SAT or A-Levels. It is a grueling annual mobilization of over ten million students, culturally rooted in the imperial civil service exams that defined Chinese meritocracy for more than a millennium. Reinstated in 1977 after the Cultural Revolution, it remains a single, high-stakes, state-run examination that solely determines admission to nearly all of China's universities. While the authors formally characterize this system as a "centralized hierarchical tournament" (p.7), their comprehensive analysis reveals it to be something even more profound: a totalizing social institution. Much like the "total social phenomenon" described by Marcel Mauss (1925/1966), the *gaokao* cannot be understood through a single lens; it is a system that simultaneously expresses economic, legal, and moral dimensions, binding the country into a single rhythm. As an institution, it acts as a foundational structure of rules and norms that organizes the life of the nation. Through this framework, the authors demonstrate how the tournament logic shapes everything from family obsession and state governance to national economic strategy and even social debates globally.

The book is organized into three main parts. Part I, "Family," explores the *gaokao*'s impact on individuals: the rational "Obsession" (Chap. 1), the unequal "Rules of the Tournament" (Chap. 2) – such as the *hukou* system – and the lifetime "Payoff" (Chap. 3). Part II, "State," turns to the government, analyzing the exam's "Political Logic" (Chap. 4), its role

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in "Centralization and the Rise of STEM" (Chap. 5), and its contribution to "Education and Global Power" (Chap. 6). Finally, Part III, "Society," examines "Values and Institutions" (Chap. 7), how the system creates "A Mirror of Society" (Chap. 8), and how "The Exam Empire Expands" (Chap. 9) globally.

Unifying these diverse perspectives is the authors' central theoretical contribution: the characterization of the Chinese education system as a centralized hierarchical tournament. This conceptual framework serves as the book's analytical spine, binding the interests of the state, the structure of society, and the behavior of the family. By framing the system as *centralized*, the authors reveal how the state retains absolute political control over talent allocation and economic planning. By describing it as *hierarchical*, they expose the rigid stratification that mirrors the broader social order, where elite university status acts as the primary currency for social mobility. Finally, by analyzing it as a *tournament*, they illuminate the brutal rationality behind family obsession; in a zero-sum game where relative performance is the only metric, extreme competition becomes the logical survival strategy.

To be sure, the *gaokao* is not an unknown phenomenon, having been explored through a rich body of English-language scholarship. Vanessa Fong's *Only Hope* (2004) famously chronicled how the One-Child Policy channeled intense parental investment into the singleton generation's exam performance. Andrew Kipnis's *Governing Educational Desire* (2011) investigated the cultural and political origins of "educational fever" in Shandong, framing it as a phenomenon governed by state discourse on population quality (*suzhi*) and local administrative ambition. Susan Bregnbæk's *Fragile Elite* (2016) shifted the gaze to the winners, documenting the profound psychological distress and hollowness experienced by students at China's top universities. More recently, Zack Howlett's *Meritocracy and Its Discontents* (2021) analyzed the exam as "fateful rites of passage," exploring the deep cultural anxiety surrounding merit in Fujian high schools. All these works traced *gaokao*'s contours.

Crucially, this conversation has been mirrored by a surge of introspection within China itself. Recent domestic scholarship has moved beyond mere academic analysis to offer poignant social critiques of the system's human toll. For instance, the documentary *Gaokao* (2015) visually captured the industrial-scale intensity of "super high schools" like Maotanchang, exposing the extreme lengths to which students and families go to survive the tournament. Meanwhile, scholars have increasingly turned their gaze away from the "winners" to the system's casualties. Deng Huang's *My Second-Tier Students* (2020) gives a human face to the "losers" relegated to non-elite universities, while Xiaoying Lin's *Children of County High Schools* (2023) documents the structural decline of county-level education, arguing these institutions are the biggest victims of the *gaokao*'s resource concentration. Even for the "winners," the victory is often shown to be pyrrhic. A growing body of work – including Meng Cheng 's *"Material for Studying"* (2018), Yajun Zheng's *After the Gold List* (2023), and Ailei Xie 's *The Small-Town Swot* (2024) – investigates the cultural dislocation of rural high-achievers. These authors collectively expose how students who ostensibly win the exam (*xiaozhen zuotijia*) often remain maladjusted outsiders, struggling to navigate the alien cultural habitus of elite urban universities.

While these works provide the qualitative texture that brings those contours to life, *The Highest Exam* distinguishes itself through its methodology. For those of us who have attempted to study the *gaokao* using quantitative methods, the paramount difficulty of accessing high-quality data is acutely felt. No singular study has been able to capture the

whole picture. Here, Jia and Li excel, demonstrating various efforts in data collection and analysis.

The evidence base for this book is built on a wide array of sources, including administrative records, large-scale surveys, and twin data. For instance, by analyzing data on all exam-takers from 2003, Li and colleagues (2015) revealed the staggering inequality of the system, finding that rural youth from poor counties were eleven times less likely to access elite colleges than their urban counterparts. Their characteristic methodology is the application of quasi-experimental identification strategies (like Regression Discontinuity) to large-scale observational datasets. They leverage natural experiments, such as historical policy shocks or the *gaokao*'s own admission cutoffs, to establish causal inference. In a representative study, Jia and Li (2021) exploited the sharp discontinuity around admission cutoffs to prove that scoring just a single point higher, and thus gaining the "elite" label, tangibly increased graduates' starting wages. Only those who have labored in this field can fully appreciate the effort it takes. Reading their work reminds anyone ambitious enough to study the Chinese system: you must be creative.

This book is the culmination of over two decades of such research (the earliest work cited from the authors dates to 2003). It also can be read as a powerful continuation from the "Stanford group" (including scholars like Prashant Loyalka, Scott Rozelle, and Xueguang Zhou). This group, linked by their Stanford affiliation and shared focus on China, is methodologically diverse. Following works from Rozelle and Hall (2022) on China's rural-urban divide and Zhou (2022) on its organizational logic, Jia, Li and Cousineau bring this macro-analytical lens to the entrance exam. Distinct from the ethnographic studies that have traditionally defined the field, their reliance on hard data and econometric models allows us, for the first time, to view the *gaokao* not just in a single village or school, but across China as a whole.

Given its authors' decorated backgrounds in economics, readers might expect an analytical driven account, but instead the book is a pleasant surprise for a non-specialist audience: not a single equation or statistical table is to be found. Aided by the captivating (and at times intimate, such as the beginning of Chap. 1 and 2) personal experiences of Jia and Li as they navigated the system themselves, and the excellent writing of Cousineau, the book provides a deeply compelling account. The authors build their argument on the three pillars of their core concept: It is centralized because the state dictates every rule of the game, from exam design to the all-important regional admission quotas. It is hierarchical because the university system is an explicit, state-funded pyramid, and a student's score solely determines their place within it. And finally, it is a tournament because it functions as a zero-sum game, pitting every student against all others in their province for a severely limited number of prized seats.

One of the successes they demonstrated, and there are many in the book, is to debunk the fairness and equity narrative associated with the *gaokao*, which most followers of test-driven meritocracy usually would argue. The three authors systematically dismantle this myth by detailing the "Rules of the Tournament" (Chap. 2). They show the system is structurally skewed from birth by two factors: the regional quota system and the *hukou* (household registration) system (pp. 59–66). The quotas mean a student in Beijing has a vastly higher chance of elite admission than a peer in Shandong or Henan (p. 60). Worse, the rigid *hukou* system creates a stark rural-urban divide, barring rural students (like co-author Jia herself, pp. 47–53) from accessing the high-quality urban K-12 schools that function as feeders for

the elite universities. This inequality is compounded by socioeconomic status, as wealthy urban families engage in an arms race of purchasing "exorbitantly priced apartments" in elite school districts (p. 96) and spending fortunes on private tutoring – advantages that are simply out of reach for most. The authors brilliantly resolve this paradox in Chap. 7: while the *gaokao* is systemically unequal, it is paradoxically cherished as "fair" because its "transparency and objectivity" (p. 162) make it the only trusted path to mobility in a society dominated by weak institutions, corruption, and connections (p. 158).

Perhaps the greatest irony of the *gaokao*, and a point where the analysis feels less developed than its focus on signaling, is its role as an educational institution. The authors are at their best when quantifying the high returns for winners (salary, benefits, and the powerful signal of achievement). Yet, they simultaneously present a new puzzle: this grueling tournament produces high school graduates who outperform global peers in critical and STEM skills (p. 75), only to be followed by a mediocre university experience. The authors note that, based on the available data, Chinese students' initial advantages stagnate or even decline during their college years, allowing their U.S., Russian, and Indian counterparts to catch up (p. 76–79). The *gaokao* is thus revealed as a world-class tournament for selection, not a gateway to a quality education, because the university system itself underdelivers.

This leads to a deeper cultural critique. While the authors rightly characterize the *gaokao* as a "centralized hierarchical tournament," problematizing the exam is effectively problematizing the operating system of the entire nation. The tournament logic is not confined to schools; it permeates every sector where the state controls the metrics of success. In this light, the *gaokao* is revealed not merely as an educational contest, but as the archetype of a totalizing tournament that organizes the entire social fabric.

For instance, this dynamic mirrors the industrial phenomenon recently analyzed by Lee (2025) regarding China's manufacturing sector. Lee identifies a brutally rational framework driving China's industrial overcapacity, where firms must "copy quickly, scale up even faster, and price aggressively" (p. 141) to survive a system where local officials maximize production-based tax revenue. The parallel to education is striking. Just as firms engage in a death spiral of price slashing to defend market share despite eroding margins, families engage in an arms race of tutoring and study hours to defend their relative ranking, even as the marginal utility of that education declines.

In both the factory and the classroom, the actors are not irrational; they are responding to a centralized system, be it the *gaokao* score or the tax structure, that rewards scale and standardization while punishing deviation. Thus, the *gaokao* does not merely shape society; it is the educational manifestation of a specific political economy where resources are allocated through a single, high-stakes game.

The authors' claim that the *gaokao*'s tournament logic extends far beyond China's borders (Chap. 9) finds grim validation in recent cultural discourse as well. An example is the 2024 Silicon Valley murder-suicide case involving two Chinese educational elites. As documented by Na Zhong (2025), the Chinese public's reaction was telling: internet sleuths immediately unearthed the couple's *gaokao* scores, fixating on their status as "top scorers" to rationalize the tragedy. That a domestic homicide in California was litigated in the court of Chinese public opinion through the lens of entrance exam scores underscores Jia and Li's central thesis: the *gaokao* is not merely an educational hurdle, but a lifelong social tattoo that defines "merit" and "worth," even for those who have ostensibly escaped the system.

Given this systemic bind, what is an individual to do? The book concludes by offering two very different answers, personified by the authors. The first, from Li, is a practical one: "opting out" by combining what he sees as the best of both systems – a rigorous Chinese primary education for his children, followed by a more creative American high school (p. 211). Li's choice is emblematic of a broader exit phenomenon that now spans the social spectrum. As Yi-Lin Chiang (2022) documents, navigating global education is a carefully calibrated strategy for the new elite, while Martin (2022) observes that studying abroad is no longer their exclusive preserve, having become a common practice for the urban middle class, particularly women seeking flight from domestic constraints. Yet, as the authors admit, such individual actions do nothing to ease the systemic pressure; they often merely displace the competition to a new, international arena. The second, more profound answer comes from Jia's concluding reflection. She identifies the root of the problem not in the exam itself, but in a society that "rewards the type of behavior necessary to climb the hierarchy while disincentivizing behaviors that foster creative destruction" (p. 210). This suggests a path forward, however difficult, through a fundamental change in societal values. This is a profound challenge, not just for China, but for any society that equates educational sorting with mobility, reminding us that real change must start with small actions—as parents, as teachers, as scholars, and as students.

This critique aside, *The Highest Exam* is a landmark contribution. It is the first data-driven yet highly accessible account of the *gaokao* at this national scope, moving the conversation beyond localized ethnography. The book is best understood as a foundational work on the political economy of Chinese higher education. *Gaokao* is an institution, not merely a bureaucratic entity, but a complex, enduring system of social rules that defines what is valued and how rewards are distributed. Jia, Li, and Cousineau use the *gaokao* as the keystone to unlock the logic of the entire system – not just college admissions, but the academic research environment and the incentive mechanisms that govern it.

Yet, the relevance of *The Highest Exam* extends far beyond the field of China studies. While the authors candidly admit that China's centralized hierarchical tournament is unique in its sheer scale and ferocity, it serves as a powerful archetype for understanding similar high-stakes testing cultures prevalent across East Asia, from South Korea to Vietnam. Furthermore, as the authors demonstrate in their final chapters, this "exam empire" has expanded globally. For educators and policymakers in Sydney, London, Toronto, or New York, this analysis provides the essential cipher for understanding the millions of Chinese students now sitting in their classrooms; to understand their resilience, their anxiety, and their definition of merit, one must first understand the *gaokao*. Jia, Li, and Cousineau have thus produced not only a definitive economic history of a Chinese institution but a vital guide to the human capital that is reshaping the world.

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